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F2. Understanding the Options

Though higher education in Canada is decentralised and falls under the jurisdiction of the country's ten provinces and three territories, Canadian universities have a robust and comprehensive quality assurance system. Each Canadian university determines its own quality assurance standards and procedures, but it is also committed to a common framework of quality standards across all Canadian provinces. This means that Canadian universities have a shared understanding of the value of one another's academic credentials and that their high-quality standards are recognized internationally.

It is therefore important for agents to know that in Canada, there is a consistently high level of quality education across the post-secondary spectrum. As we can see via global rankings and Canada's competitive economy, graduates emerge with internationally accepted and well-respected credentials on par with top institutions in the US, UK, and other OECD countries.

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Agents should know that:

Canada offers a variety of university settings, depending on the student's personality and interests. If the student is looking for a campus with large research facilities in a buzzing urban centre, it's here. If they prefer a small liberal arts institution in a quiet rural setting, this is also an option. Canada also has medium-sized comprehensive institutions that will range from about 1,000 to 25,000 students—these types of universities are located in a variety of urban centres such as Halifax, Sherbrooke, Kingston, Peterborough, Thunder Bay, Saskatoon, and Victoria.

Canada's universities grant a full range of degrees, from three- to four-year bachelor's degrees, to master's degrees and doctorates (PhD). Other options include professional degrees in medicine, law, architecture, and dentistry to name a few, as well as certificates, diplomas, and shorter career-focused programs.

Many universities offer full-time and part-time enrolment options as well as cooperative education, distance learning, and continuing education.

Programs are offered in English or French; some institutions offer instruction in both official languages. Some offer French studies in English cities—there are 14 Francophone universities in provinces other than Quebec—and some offer English studies in French cities. Regardless of the language of instruction, some programs or institutions allow students to hand in work and/or write their exams in the official language of their choice.

There is online and distance education in Canada: International students who want a Canadian education but cannot, for whatever reason, study abroad, may be very interested in online learning. Most universities and colleges across Canada have dramatically expanded their online and hybrid study options in recent years, and students will find a wide range of programmes available.

There are many excellent Canadian language programs to help international students with language proficiency and enable them to be accepted into post-secondary studies. A separate section in this course is devoted to language programs.

Graduate Studies and Research in Canada

There are three types of graduate degrees:

- **Course-based master's degree:** This requires successful completion of specific graduate-level courses and is typically one or two years in duration.
- **Research-based master's degree:** Requires completion of both graduate-level courses and a thesis and is typically two years in duration. Graduate students usually choose a thesis topic in consultation with a graduate supervisor, although many universities require a statement of research interests as part of the application process.
- **Doctorate or PhD degree:** Requires completion of original research and defense of a thesis that makes a substantial contribution to the chosen field of study and is typically at least four years in duration.

When students pursue their research goals in Canada, they become valued members of a community that is internationally recognized for research excellence and enjoys a long-standing tradition of delivering on discovery. Canada supports researchers through such prestigious programs as the Canada Research Chairs, Canada Excellence Research Chairs, and Vanier and Banting scholarships.

Canadian universities spin-off research-based companies at a truly impressive rate. Canada is home to life-changing innovations like insulin, the electron microscope, the cardiac pacemaker, and the Canadarm used in space exploration.

International students pursuing post-graduate studies in Canada are also eligible for the Post-Graduation Work Program, designed to provide graduating students with Canadian work experience in their fields of study. Please find out more [here](#).

Financial Assistance

Canada is among the most affordable of the leading study-abroad destinations, and there are a number of scholarship and award programs at the undergraduate and graduate levels to assist international students. This financial aid is awarded based on criteria such as academic success, community involvement, athletic excellence, references from instructors and employers, or purely financial need. Please see the section on COSTS OF STUDY for more details.

Quality Assurance

While there is no national accreditation body for universities in Canada, provincial legislation and universities' membership in [Universities Canada](#) ensure that universities maintain the high standards that allow Canadian degrees and other credentials to be recognized and respected across the world.

Membership in Universities Canada is granted through a rigorous process of peer review. Institutions must demonstrate adherence to all Universities Canada membership criteria, which include:

- Good governance and administrative structure;
- Highly qualified faculty with PhDs;
- Academic programs of university standard;
- Access to library and other learning resources appropriate to the institution's mission, goals and programs;
- Robust quality assurance policy;
- Respect for academic freedom, intellectual integrity, and intellectual property;
- A not-for-profit basis of operations.

Did You Know?

The variety of programs offered by Canadian universities is astounding. Here are just some examples from the thousands offered across Canadian universities:

- Bachelor of Business Administration
 - Bachelor of Journalism
 - Bachelor of Medical Imaging
 - Bachelor of Science in Applied Plant and Soil Sciences
 - Bachelor of Science in Nutrition
 - Bachelor of Science in Computer Science
 - Bachelor of Science in Neuroscience and Mental Health
 - Bachelor of Science in Pharmacy
 - Certificate in Special Education
 - Certificate in Business Fundamentals
 - Fashion Design Diploma
 - Master of International Affairs
 - Master of Natural Resources and Environmental Sciences
 - Master of Fine Arts in Creative Writing
 - Doctor of Dental Medicine in Dentistry
 - PhD in Medical Genetics
 - Speech and Language Assistant Diploma
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Learning in Canadian Universities

International students will naturally feel both excited about studying in a different culture and education system and worried about fitting in and succeeding. The agent will want to let them know something about what it's like to study at a university in Canada.

The following (modified) excerpt from a document created by a very internationally focused university, Thompson Rivers University, summarizes some of the characteristics of studying in Canada at the post-secondary level:

Attendance

Attendance is important in Canada; students do not simply receive their grades based on one final exam. Attendance is seen as an indication of commitment from the student.

Participation

In many countries, students receive a passive, rather than active, orientation toward learning, in which they are expected to simply listen and receive information. But in Canada, questioning and critical thinking are expected at the post-secondary level; students are encouraged to speak out in class and/or volunteer answers.

Lower Level of Formality

Most international students are surprised by the “informal” relationship between instructors and students in Canadian educational institutions. It may take some time before they feel comfortable asking questions or offering an opinion. They may initially be embarrassed or unsettled by direct communication with instructors. Instructors are definitely the experts in the classroom, but they are open to receiving feedback and encouraging discussion among students.

Evaluation

The process of evaluation at a university/college is often new to students from other countries. They may be accustomed to being graded on the basis of one final exam and are unused to progressive evaluation throughout the term. They may not be aware that attendance, participation, projects, and small quizzes can contribute to a cumulative grade.

Individual and Group Work

The distinction we make in Canada between individual and group work is not always shared by other cultures. In Canada, individual work is expected to be original and not the result of a group of friends doing the work together and each submitting the same content. With group work, students are expected to fully participate; this is why language support is important for international students: it helps them be more confident in engaging in group situations.

Academic Honesty

The meaning of academic honesty is difficult for many students to fully grasp. The concept of plagiarism may be new for many international students who may never have been required or taught to properly cite sources. In some educational environments, information is a public commodity; ownership of ideas is not recognized in the same way it is here. In addition, in many cultures, it is preferable to quote the “expert” rather than to paraphrase in one’s own words.

*From (with minor modifications) TRU: A Globally Minded Campus, available on the **TRU World website***

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